

Is Your GTM Built for a Complex Market?

*A practical diagnostic for technology companies entering,
repositioning in, or growing within specialized markets*



Why This Guide Exists

When a technology company enters a complex market, the advice is often familiar: publish more content, run more campaigns, reach out to more prospects. But when buyers are specialized, sales cycles are long and the path to purchase is complicated, more activity doesn't necessarily create more traction.

The harder question is whether your GTM is built around how that market actually buys: where demand forms, who influences the decision, when you need to engage, what alternatives buyers are considering, and what proof they need before choosing you.

The tactics that work well in conventional SaaS markets don't always translate when buyers, procurement processes and sales cycles are more complex.

This guide is a short diagnostic. It covers seven areas where go-to-market plans in complex markets most often stall, with practical tips and examples from my own work. At the end, a scorecard helps you identify where your biggest gaps are.

Who This Guide Is For

Leaders of technology companies with a strong, complex product who are entering, repositioning in, or growing within a specialized market. These are often niche or technical markets with complex buyers, longer sales cycles, and less predictable paths to growth.

What Makes a Market Complex?

A complex market isn't simply a small or specialized market. It's a market where buying decisions involve multiple stakeholders, longer timelines, formal evaluation or procurement processes, established alternatives, or significant perceived risk.

If the way your market buys is more complicated than a typical self-serve or straightforward B2B SaaS sale, this guide is for you.



Tina Peng

Principal, Tina Peng GTM Consulting

The Perspective Behind This Guide

I've spent 15+ years helping technology companies bring complex products to market, across B2B SaaS, satellite and defence communications, and other specialized technology markets.

The common thread wasn't a particular industry. It was the challenge of selling something complex to buyers who don't all care about the same things, often through long and unfamiliar buying processes.

I've seen what happens when companies apply standard SaaS marketing tactics to those markets, and what changes when the GTM strategy starts with how the market actually buys.

That's the thinking behind this guide: seven areas to pressure-test your GTM before putting more money and effort into execution.

1. The Complex-Market Test

Complex markets normally share a few traits: buying committees, long sales cycles, formal gates and established incumbents. A typical B2B buying decision now involves 13 internal stakeholders and nine external influencers (Forrester, 2026). Across B2B purchases in general, the average buying cycle ran about 10 months in 2025 (6sense, 2025), and purchases in complex markets often take longer.

13 + 9

Internal stakeholders and external influencers in a typical B2B buying decision (Forrester, 2026)

~10 months

Average B2B buying cycle in 2025, across all B2B purchases (6sense, 2025)

Your GTM may need a different approach if:

- ☐ Your pipeline depends heavily on referrals and inbound inquiries.
- ☐ You often learn about opportunities only after an RFP is published.
- ☐ Your team has relationships with users but not with budget owners or procurement.
- ☐ You're producing content but don't know which target accounts it reaches.
- ☐ You get shortlisted but lose to incumbents.
- ☐ Your founder still explains the product in every important sales conversation.
- ☐ Your positioning changes depending on who is in the room.
- ☐ You know your product is differentiated, but buyers don't seem to see why.

If three or more sound familiar, the sections that follow will help you find where your plan is breaking down.

2. Find Where Demand Is Forming

In some complex markets, buying signals appear in public sources long before a buyer makes contact.

Signal	Where to look
Public spending plans	Budgets, departmental plans, capability blueprints
Regulatory deadlines	Regulator websites and reporting calendars
Procurement notices	Procurement portals, RFIs and industry days
Institutional plans and funding cycles	University strategic and capital plans, funder and grant calendars

Canadian defence is one clear example. Canada has committed to reach 5% of GDP on defence by 2035 (National Defence, 2026), and its Defence Industrial Strategy aims to award 70% of defence acquisitions to Canadian firms (Government of Canada, 2026). The same pattern shows up when regulators set compliance deadlines, universities publish capital plans or funders open grant cycles. The plan is public well before purchasing begins.

Tip: Turn these signals into a short list of five to ten target accounts. Rank them by fit, size and how early you can still influence the outcome.

FROM THE FIELD

Narrowing the market to win it

A custom software and AI workflow studio could build almost anything, so its marketing spoke to almost everyone. Inquiries were sporadic, and many came from leads that were quickly disqualified as a poor fit. The team's first response was to use the latest AI tools to increase outreach volume. The real issue was focus. We defined three buyer personas and mapped each one's buying journey and the triggers that prompt them to act. That work produced a focused target account list, and outreach response rates improved notably.

Takeaway: In a niche market, every contact is scarce. Precision beats volume.

3. Map the Real Buying Committee

The people who approve the budget, write the evaluation criteria and sign the contract are often different from the people who use your product. Each one needs something different from you.



Role	What they need to know
Users	Does it solve the problem in their daily work?
Budget holders	Is it worth the cost, and is the funding approved?
Evaluators	Does it meet the specifications and criteria?
Gatekeepers	Is it safe, legal and compliant to buy?
Sponsors	Does it support the organization's wider goals?

Many large organizations split the decision between the people who define the need and the people who control the budget and run the evaluation. In defence, the operational side defines the capability, while a separate team manages the budget, writes the specifications and sets the evaluation criteria. Universities, regulated companies and public agencies often work the same way. Vendors who only build relationships with users can miss the people who set the criteria.

Tip: For each target account, note who fills each role, what decision they influence and the one message that matters most to them.

FROM THE FIELD

Demos built for the buying committee

An enterprise data platform for extended producer responsibility and stewardship compliance had a strong product. Its marketing focused on features and tried to list every capability. We helped the team understand the buying committee and build a demo plan for each meeting based on who was invited. Demos became better targeted to each stakeholder's questions and needs, which led to better sales conversations and stronger pipeline advancement.

Takeaway: Each person in the buying committee needs to see how the product answers their own questions.

4. Get In Before the RFP

By the time a formal request for proposals is published, the requirements are written and buyers often have a favourite. 94% of B2B buying groups rank their shortlist before speaking with a seller, and the pre-contact favourite wins 77% of the time (6sense, 2025).

94%

of B2B buying groups rank their shortlist before speaking with a seller (6sense, 2025)

77%

of the time, the pre-contact favourite wins the deal (6sense, 2025)

The practical implication is straightforward: the later you enter the process, the fewer opportunities you have to influence the decision.

In complex markets, the RFP usually marks the end of the stage where you can shape the deal, not the start of the sale.

Tips:

- Respond to RFIs and attend industry days, even if you won't be the lead bidder.
- Help the people writing requirements understand what's possible today. Candid input builds trust.
- Know the rules. In Canadian federal procurement, contacting requirement owners after an RFP is released can disqualify your bid.

FROM THE FIELD

Turning booth time into meetings

A services firm was attending industry trade shows with little follow-up structure. We built a simple toolkit for the sales development rep: a process for booking meetings before the event, a talk track for the booth, a follow-up email and a nurture sequence. The rule became simple: no trade show investment without meetings booked in advance.

Takeaway: Investing in a trade show pays off when the meetings are booked before you arrive.

5. Build Your Route to Market

Smaller companies often reach complex buyers through partners: prime contractors, systems integrators, resellers with existing contracts, advisory firms and industry associations. A trusted partner reduces the risk a buyer sees in choosing you.

Partners take on risk too, so they look for companies that fill a capability gap, add local content or industrial benefits, or bring certifications they need.

Tips:

- Get known before the bid. Primes and integrators invite suppliers they already know to their own competitions.
- Consider teaming with complementary companies. A group can offer more than each company can alone.
- Treat reputation as a channel. In specialized communities, word of mouth travels fast.

FROM THE FIELD

Speaking the buyer's language

At a Canadian satellite and defence communications manufacturer, the end users were military personnel, so marketing had to reflect how those users actually worked and communicated. We adapted sales materials, training content and product interfaces to their terminology and operating context. That attention to the user's world helped establish credibility with one military customer, and word of mouth opened conversations with others.

Takeaway: In specialized markets, trust earned with one respected customer opens doors with the next.

6. Make Yourself Easy to Buy

In complex markets, procurement doesn't end when the buyer says yes. Security reviews, vendor registration, certifications, privacy assessments and implementation requirements can delay a contract even after you've been selected.

Tips:

- Name one person to own security and compliance readiness. It can start as a part-time role.
- Identify the requirements for your top target contracts now, and start the long lead-time items early.
- Show continuity. Partners, documented processes, a support plan and references from similar clients help a buyer trust a smaller team.

7. Position Against the Status Quo

Your toughest competition is often an incumbent supplier, an in-house team or the decision to do nothing. Buyers compare you with what they already use, so your positioning needs to start from their frame of reference.

Tips:

- List your top five alternatives, including the status quo.
- Test each differentiator with three questions: does the buyer care, can you prove it, and is it hard to copy?
- To displace an incumbent, time your outreach to contract renewals and offer a low-risk first step such as a pilot.
- Lead with capability and results. Being Canadian or local helps most as a tiebreaker.

FROM THE FIELD

Repositioning around how buyers buy

Within a large B2B software portfolio, an HR product was marketed as a standalone solution. Buyers thought of it as an add-on to payroll, which they already trusted. Repositioning HR as a natural extension of payroll made the value clear to existing customers and simplified the sales conversation. The HR attach rate among renewing payroll accounts grew from 5% to 15%.

Takeaway: Buyers compare you with what they already use. Position around their frame of reference.

8. Your 90-Day GTM Plan

A focused 90 days is enough to build the foundation for momentum in a complex market.

DAYS 1 TO 30

Focus

- Pick one market and five to ten target accounts.
- Map the buying committee at your top three accounts.
- Complete the scorecard on the next page.
- Set up your CRM to track accounts, stakeholders and pipeline stages.

DAYS 31 TO 60

Engage

- Start outreach to the stakeholders on your map.
- Respond to relevant RFIs and register for industry days.
- Begin conversations with two or three potential partners.
- Start long lead-time readiness items such as certifications or security screening.

DAYS 61 TO 90

Test

- Tailor your messaging for each role in the buying committee.
- Commit to one event, with meetings booked in advance.
- Propose a pilot or small first project to your most engaged account.
- Review what's working and adjust your target list.



Your Complex-Market GTM Scorecard

Score each item: 0 means not started, 1 means in progress, and 2 means in place.

Area	Item	Score (0 to 2)
Market	Ideal customer profile (ICP) defined	
	Demand signals identified	
	Target accounts defined	
	Buying timeline understood	
	Market subtotal	/ 8
Buyer	Buying committee mapped	
	Budget owner identified	
	Procurement process understood	
	Buyer subtotal	/ 6
Positioning	Alternatives and incumbents identified	
	Differentiators proven with evidence	
	Messaging defined for each stakeholder	
	Positioning subtotal	/ 6
Market access	Partners identified	
	Relationships in place before the RFP	
	Security, certifications and registrations underway	
	Market access subtotal	/ 6
Total		/ 26

Use the scorecard to identify where your biggest gaps are. Those gaps give you a starting point for deciding what to investigate and address first.

What Your Score Means

22 to 26	A strong foundation Your GTM is built for a complex market. Focus on execution, and keep an eye on your lowest-scoring area as you scale.
18 to 21	Solid, with gaps to close The basics are in place, but gaps in one or two areas are likely slowing deals or letting competitors get in earlier.
Under 18	Your pipeline is vulnerable Incumbents and better-positioned competitors are likely shaping deals before you get involved. Start with your lowest-scoring area before adding more marketing activity.

Look at your subtotals too. Any area scoring less than half its points (under 4 of 8 for Market, or under 3 of 6 for the others) is where to start.

If you scored under 18 out of 26, your pipeline is highly vulnerable to incumbents. Let's review your lowest-scoring areas together in a 30-minute diagnostic.

Book your diagnostic: hello@tinapeng.ca or message me on [LinkedIn](#)

Where I Come In

If the scorecard shows gaps in your market, buyer or positioning strategy, that's where I can help.

I work with technology companies entering, repositioning in, or growing within specialized markets, helping them identify the right market opportunity, understand how buyers make decisions, sharpen their positioning and turn that into a practical GTM plan.

The work is grounded in the market and the buying process, not a generic SaaS playbook.

Recent work includes:

- **Custom software and AI studio:** Defined three buyer personas and a focused target account list. Outreach response rates improved notably.
- **Compliance data platform:** Mapped the buying committee and built demo plans for each stakeholder. Sales conversations and pipeline advancement improved.
- **Enterprise software portfolio:** Repositioned an HR product around payroll. Attach rate grew from 5% to 15% of renewing accounts.

Book a 30-Minute GTM Diagnostic

We'll identify the biggest GTM constraint in your target market and what I'd prioritize over the next 90 days.

Email: hello@tinapeng.ca

Website: www.tinapeng.ca

LinkedIn: linkedin.com/in/tinapeng

Location: Vancouver, BC

Sources

- [6sense, 2025 B2B Buyer Experience Report \(November 2025\)](#)
- [6sense, "The Timeline for Influencing B2B Buyers Is Shrinking" \(November 2025\)](#)
- [Forrester, The State of Business Buying, 2026 \(January 2026\)](#)
- [National Defence, Senate committee appearance on NATO 2% and priorities \(April 2026\)](#)
- [Government of Canada, Canada's Defence Industrial Strategy \(February 2026\)](#)

© 2026 Tina Peng GTM Consulting. All rights reserved. This guide is provided for informational purposes only and should not be considered specific advice for your situation.